

The IT services business grows because of the people in it, who in turn keep growing by acquiring knowledge and by continuously reskilling themselves. Let's start off by looking at the key skilling opportunities for individuals in the people-supply chain of an IT company as it grows over a period of time. We will also study how such opportunities impact the IT business. We will then trace the gradual adoption of e-learning by a typical IT company, to fill certain competency requirements over the last two decades. We will also learn about how the adoption of e-learning in such situations has helped the company meet competency challenges, thereby supporting the IT business in its need for new skills.

Programmes required for skilling new entrants

During the early flourishing years of the Indian software industry, the essential skills to get placed in the top tier IT companies were good problem-solving skills, analytical abilities, communication skills and an interest in programming (optional). This, more or less, remains true even today, with more emphasis perhaps on programming. This scenario is, however, fast changing with new technologies challenging the business models for customers as well as IT companies, through low-level job automation, cloud computing and artificial intelligence taking over mundane work, giving way to more creative problem-solving opportunities.

Last year, about 200,000 graduates (NASSCOM report at <http://www.nasscom.in/research-reports>) were absorbed by the IT companies during campus placements across the country. When graduates join a company, a majority get trained in a competency programme that lasts about a quarter of a year, to understand the intricacies of IT projects and thereby be able to productively contribute to them. These competency programmes are, typically, scheduled ILT (instructor-led training) sessions. Instructors with experience in projects, soft skills experts and executives from the leadership ranks take sessions in classrooms to train the future workforce on the various technological, behavioural and leadership aspects of their jobs. This has gradually become a strategic differentiator for the IT businesses, morphing into a core aspect of creating an adequate supply of talent for the IT industry. Currently, the specific challenge that the IT industry faces is the large number of graduates to be trained in project skills, technical skills and behavioural skills (like communication, teamwork, etc) in the shortest possible time.

Competency programmes for people who move from one project to another

The duration of IT projects ranges from anywhere between three to eight months. These projects have team structures that have members at distributed locations, often across two to five countries/cities. The projects start thin on team

size—a few experts initiate the project and then it ramps up to peak team size during the construction phase, before scaling down to a few members towards the end of the project. The nature of software projects creates situations wherein an employee (individual) in the company may be actively involved in a project, move out of it (when it is scaled down) or be waiting to join a project (also called the bench). All these situations call for skilling of employees for the business reasons listed below.

In project: Technology changes very quickly and projects require specialised technical skills. Team members require competency before they can be productive enough to build the software that meets technical and customer needs. The project outcomes often show up in the feedback captured as part of the customer satisfaction ratings.

Moving off the project: To ensure the profitability of the business, employees moving off a project must necessarily be skilled on other project skills that are in demand to reduce or eliminate the non-billing hours associated with them. This indirectly influences the engagement levels of employees which, in turn, impacts attrition. In a people-intensive business like IT services, attrition is a parameter of high interest for stakeholders and investors.

All of the above situations are opportunities for the competency function to create initiatives and solutions to skill employees.

Career paths

Providing well-defined and clearly communicated career options is a critical HR strategy in a people-intensive business. This is to ensure employees have a view of how their careers will evolve in the company and the rewards of associating with the business in the longer term, including their professional growth. Competency management is a very significant part of creating a career path for employees, and includes options like switching career streams for growth that match the employee's strengths and interests.

Employee performance and development

At the end of a project, employees are evaluated for their performance on the project. If needed, developmental plans are created to help employees overcome certain weaknesses that hampered them from meeting business requirements. Again, this is an opportunity for the competency development function to create programmes for employees to increase their skills in areas identified in the development plans.

It goes without saying that rapid and relevant reskilling in the required and in-demand skills, through training, has a profound impact on the IT business' performance. The need for building competence arises repeatedly during the career of an IT professional in a thriving IT business. So let's look at whether e-learning technologies are meeting these challenges, either fully or partially.